outward as the Andronovo people. *Aryans* notes that fragments of the early society of these steppe nomads can be found in the earliest Indo-Aryan texts, from the Vedas to the Mahabharata, but the early Indian Aryans are only intelligible in light of the synthesis with the earlier Indus Valley Civilisation.

Near the end of Allen's life, paleogenetics emerged as a field, and his narrative ends with the controversies and conclusions that emerged out of the work of researchers like David Reich and Niraj Rai. Again, politics intersects with scholarship, as *Aryans* dissects contested claims by various scholars motivated by the search for truth and political palatability. What the DNA clearly shows is that the steppe ancestry found in modern Indians is a relative latecomer, not present in the Indus Valley Civilisation populations, and likely correlates with movements of Andronovo-descended societies after 1800 BC through the Bactria-Margiana Culture (BMAC) into modern-day Pakistan, Afghanistan and Iran.

DNA has not cleared up all the mysteries, nor is archaeology or linguistics a closed book. But *Aryans* shows that we are likely most of the way there. The early Aryans were cultural revolutionaries, domesticating the modern horse and pioneering the deployment of war chariots. This transformation allowed them to dominate the Eurasian steppe for thousands of years before the rise of the Turks, and enabled their intrusion into the rich and populous lands to their south. It is perhaps a supreme irony of history that the prehistoric shamans of the Ural valley 4,000 years ago would leave their strongest cultural mark on the Brahmins of modern India, thousands of miles away in a clime and culture entirely alien to the original Aryans. ■

–Razib Khan

